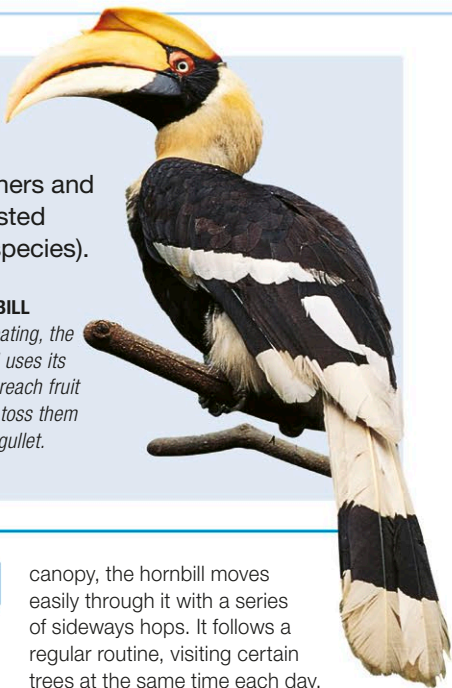


Hoopoes and hornbills

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Bucerotiformes
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	74

These two groups are quite distinct, and previously grouped together with kingfishers and rollers in a very diverse order. The hoopoe is a ground-living, boldly barred and crested species, with six or eight subspecies or races (two are sometimes considered full species). A separate group of nine glossy, long-tailed species are the more socially organized wood hoopoes. Hornbills are mostly forest or savanna woodland birds, but the very large ground hornbills form a separate subgroup. They all have long, tapered bills, some adorned with decorative casques. The length and fine but strong tips aid feeding, but the color and shape are clearly for show, and largely related to species recognition and display.

GREAT HORNBILL
Mainly fruit-eating, the great hornbill uses its long beak to reach fruit on trees and toss them back into its gullet.



Upupa epops

Eurasian hoopoe



Location Europe, Asia, Africa, Madagascar

Length 11 in (28 cm)
Weight 2½ oz (75 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



With its bold colors, long, curved bill, and fan-shaped crest, the hoopoe is unmistakable. It spends much of the day on the ground, probing the soil with

its bill in search of insects. Its diet also includes earthworms, snails, slugs, and spiders. This bird has an undulating flight with strong wingbeats interspersed by pauses. Hoopoes are notoriously foul-smelling and unhygienic; the fetid state of their nests, arising from the accumulation of excreta, food remains, and the nestlings' body secretions, is thought to deter predators.



Buceros bicornis

Great hornbill



Location S. and S.E. Asia

Length 5 ft (1.5 m)
Weight 6½ lb (3 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened



The most spectacular of the hornbills, this species is distinguished by its large size, resounding call, and the loud "swooshing" of its wingbeats. It has a massive bill with a prominent casque, and long, rounded wings. The bill, casque, white head, and neck are often stained yellow with oil from the preen gland. Mostly confined to the forest

canopy, the hornbill moves easily through it with a series of sideways hops. It follows a regular routine, visiting certain trees at the same time each day. It feeds mainly on fruit, especially figs, but also preys on reptiles, amphibians, small mammals, and birds. Fruit and small prey are grasped with the tip of the bill and moved down the gullet by throwing the head up and back. Larger prey is crushed in the bill and battered against a branch before being swallowed. Like other hornbills, this species builds its nest in the natural hollow of a tree trunk, which it seals with mud, leaving only a narrow opening through which the male passes food to the nesting female. The female breaks out of the nest after almost 3 months, but the entrance is resealed by the chick, which is fed for a further month in the nest.

Phoeniculus purpureus

Green wood hoopoe



Location Africa (south of Sahara)

Length 15 in (38 cm)
Weight 2½ oz (75 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



This slim bird has a long tail and a slender, downcurved bill. The plumage is black with an iridescent sheen of green and dark violet that changes color and intensity with differing light sources. The bill is adapted to probing for insects in crevices or under bark as the bird climbs through trees. Green wood hoopoes live in close-knit groups, which include up to 16 birds headed by a dominant pair. When neighbouring groups meet, a peculiar "flag waving" display often ensues, with one or 2 birds waving pieces of bark in the air. The other members clump together, rocking their bodies and calling loudly.

Tockus leucomelas

Southern yellow-billed hornbill



Location Southern Africa

Length 20–23½ in (50–60 cm)
Weight 9 oz (250 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



This small hornbill has a curved, bright yellow bill and black wings with white spots. It feeds on insects and fruit, especially figs. This species sometimes forms cooperative foraging parties with dwarf mongooses, which flush out locusts on which the birds feed. The hornbill, in turn, warns them of approaching danger.



Bucorvus leadbeateri

Southern ground hornbill



Location Southern Africa

Length 4¼ ft (1.3 m)
Weight Not recorded
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Vulnerable



This turkey-sized bird, and the Abyssinian ground hornbill (*Bucorvus abyssinicus*), are the 2 largest hornbills,

and among the few that feed mainly on the ground. Its plumage is almost entirely black, apart from white wing patches, and its most conspicuous feature is a patch of bare, brightly colored skin on its face and throat. The male has a red wattle, whereas the female's is blue. Southern ground hornbills live in groups of up to 8 birds, and feed mainly on small animals. They nest in tree holes, but in each group only the dominant pair breeds—the junior birds help collect food and defend the nest.

